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Legislature approves $50 million for litigation of Trump actions - Legal Defense funding

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On Jan. 23, Governor Gavin Newsom signed two bills appropriating $2.5 billion to help fund the recovery efforts in Los Angeles area after the devastation caused by multiple wildfires. The burning began Jan. 7. The Governor's press release described the damage as hurricane-force fire storms.

This was only 10 days after he made the request of the Legislature's Special Session. Both bills, ABX1-4 and SBX1-3, provide more than $2.5 billion for disaster relief and were passed unanimously.

"Thanks to our partners in the legislature, we're providing over $2.5 billion in immediate relief – expediting initial firestorm response and recovery efforts," Newsom said in the release. "We're also directing millions of dollars to help local governments speed up building approvals – so folks can rebuild their homes faster."

As of Jan. 25, Cal Fire reported that the various Los Angeles area fires have caused 28 fatalities and burned and destroyed more than 16,000 structures.

Nearly all of the $2.5 billion is intended to expedite the initial response and recovery efforts. These funds would help offset costs associated with the emergency protective measures, evacuations, sheltering for survivors, debris removal and cleanup, post-fire hazard assessments (such as flash flooding and debris flows), traffic control, and other necessary emergency response activities.

There is a separate $5 million appropriation for rebuilding. The Department of Housing and Community Development will receive $4 million for local governments in the fire areas. This will be used for additional planning review and building inspection resources to expedite building approvals during the recovery period.

Another $1 million is targeted at fire-damaged school facilities. Its purpose is to aid the school districts to rebuild damaged structures. The funding will provide technical assistance to Los Angeles Unified School District, Pasadena Unified School District, and charter schools affected by the fires.

"The money will come from the state's reserve fund dedicated to economic uncertainties, which had about $8.3 billion as of Jan. 10, according to the H.D. Palmer, spokesperson for California's Department of Finance," Cal Matters reported.

"This money is moving immediately and was approved unanimously with bipartisan support," said Jesse Gabriel, chair of the Assembly's Budget Committee. "It's the first of many steps and there will be a lot of steps in this journey.

Besides seeking the Legislature's approval of supplemental funding to help the victims and the recovery, Newsom has issued a number of Executive Orders to address the problems of the victims and the local jurisdictions' recovery efforts.

"It is very meaningful for me as legislator for Southern California to see people of parts of the state stand up and say, 'We'll be with you'," Gabriel also said in his statement.

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